

## **FS 415 Final Essay**

**Student Name:** Vansh Singh

**Student ID:** 1739805

As the global media landscape continues to evolve, it profoundly influences cultural identities worldwide, challenging the dominance of Western media and fostering a rich tapestry of diverse narratives that resonate across global audiences. In this complex interplay, media is not merely a reflection of societal values but an active participant in shaping and reshaping cultural identities.

This essay asserts that the interface between global media and local cultures transcends the mere proliferation of consumer and brand identities, fostering instead the emergence of hybrid cultural identities. This phenomenon challenges the homogenizing force of globalization, suggesting a vibrant coexistence of local and global narratives that mutually influence one another.

Drawing upon foundational concepts from the course (FS 415), this essay asserts that global media flows have catalyzed the development of new forms of cultural hybridity, which benefit authentic local cultural expression. This hybridity represents a synthesis of local traditions with global influences, offering a nuanced dialogue that reshapes cultural identity.

This analysis will engage with a range of critical perspectives to explore the synthesis of global and local cultural narratives. We will draw upon Brian Larkin's examination of Nigerian cinema, highlighting the dual resistance to and incorporation of global influences within local media forms. Hyejung Ju's study of the international dissemination of Korean dramas will illustrate how global platforms like Netflix facilitate new forms of cultural hybridity. Jing Wang's insights into how China's middle class blends global consumer culture

with traditional values will be discussed, alongside Cynthia Chan's exploration of how young Chinese use fashion and consumer culture to craft and express their social identities in a globalized context. Together, these readings will anchor our analysis, demonstrating the complex interplay between global media forces and local cultural identities.

The globalization of the media landscape has positioned global media as a pivotal conduit for cultural exchange, significantly enhancing the global audience's access to diverse cultural productions. Shows like "Squid Game" offer insights into Korean society while engaging with universally relatable themes such as socio-economic struggle, thereby fostering a cross-cultural dialogue that enriches global cultural understanding. Concurrently, global media serves as a vehicle for economic interests, leveraging cultural content for market expansion and revenue generation. The strategic placement of shows on platforms like Netflix, which tailors content to maximize viewer engagement across different regions, exemplifies how economic motives are deeply embedded in the dissemination of cultural products. This strategy not only influences what content is made available but also shapes how it is produced, marketed, and received worldwide, revealing a complex interplay between cultural and economic forces in the globalization of media.

Brian Larkin's analysis of Nigerian cinema, particularly his discussion in "Extravagant Aesthetics: Instability and the Excessive World of Nigerian Film," illuminates the dynamic and self-constructed identity of local media forms in Nigeria. These forms exhibit a unique blend of resistance and integration of global influences, challenging the notion of cultural homogenization. Larkin articulates, *"In the logic of modernization theory, media were expected to be the technologies that effected the labor of making Nigerians modern"* (Larkin, 2008, p. 168). This statement introduces the significant role media plays in shaping cultural identities and modernity perceptions, aligning with the broader impacts of global media flows on national identities.

Further, Larkin observes, "*Video [Nigerian] films collapse the divide between state and commercial media, between Nigerians and foreigners, and between uplift and escapism*" (Larkin, 2008, p. 168). This observation underscores how Nigerian films, particularly those from Nollywood, creatively merge various cultural elements. Such films do not merely mix traditional and global influences; they actively engage these elements to forge new forms of cultural expression. This blending acts as a testament to the potential of global media flows to enrich local cultural expressions by introducing innovative resources and frameworks for creativity.

Moreover, Larkin comments on the deeper implications of these cinematic expressions, noting, "*Nigerian films evoke their world's constantly shifting sands*" where traditional and modern elements either merge or conflict, reflecting the nation's ongoing struggle with post-colonial identity and economic disparities (Larkin, 2008, p.170). This portrayal extends beyond artistic choice, mirroring the socio-economic challenges faced by many Nigerians. It highlights the intertwined nature of cultural and economic dimensions within global media narratives, emphasizing the complex and multifaceted impact of global media on local settings. Through this lens, Larkin's work contributes to a nuanced understanding of how global media not only transforms but also becomes a part of local cultural landscapes, fostering a dynamic interplay between global influences and local realities.

Hyejung Ju's insightful analysis in her essay "K-Dramas Meet Netflix" explores the transformative impact of global streaming platforms like Netflix on the distribution and cultural reception of Korean dramas. Ju illustrates how the extensive reach of these platforms contributes to a phenomenon she terms '*detrterritorialization*,' where the geographical and

cultural origins of these dramas are transcended, suggesting a potential decrease in the emphasis on national identities as the content becomes globally accessible (Ju, 2020, p. 172).

This shift from traditional media distribution channels is significant, as Ju points out that *"Netflix's recommendation algorithm encourages international audiences to check on a list of K-dramas on the site"* (Ju, 2020, p. 171). This strategic positioning by Netflix caters to a diverse global audience, promoting a consumer identity that is less tied to nationality and more influenced by consumer preferences. This observation supports the idea that global media flows contribute to the rise of consumer and brand identities, as viewers are influenced more by Netflix's brand and its curated content than by their own national or local media productions.

Furthermore, Ju argues that the global platforms like Netflix facilitate new forms of cultural hybridity where local elements are not only preserved but celebrated and integrated into the global media landscape. She states, *"The notion of transculturality in the media...sheds light on the changing dynamics of cultural exchanges"* (Ju, 2020, p. 172). This suggests that rather than diluting local cultures, global platforms can enhance them by fostering a dynamic interplay between local particularities and global narratives. Ju also highlights the emotional engagement elicited by these dramas, noting that *"Western viewers, though unfamiliar with Korean culture, relate to and identify with Korean content, suggesting a shared sociocultural background"* (Ju, 2020, pg. 173). This deep cultural and emotional resonance illustrates how global media significantly contributes to enriching rather than homogenizing the cultural landscape.

Expanding on these points, Chris Barker's framework on the global-local nexus and the relationship between capitalism and modernity provides further insight. Barker suggests that global processes and local realities are not antagonistic but interdependent, continually influencing each other. This interdependence indicates that modern capitalism, through global

media platforms like Netflix, does not merely exploit cultural products but enables their adaptation in a manner that respects and incorporates local narratives. Such an approach not only challenges traditional power dynamics but also promotes a more equitable cultural exchange. This nuanced interaction allows local cultures to leverage global media to amplify their voice within the global narrative, transforming traditional notions of cultural identity and fostering a rich, multifaceted global culture.

Jing Wang's analysis in "Bourgeois Bohemians in China" offers profound insights into how the burgeoning middle class in China has harnessed global consumer culture to carve out a distinct identity that blends traditional Chinese elements with modern consumerist values. Wang's depiction of the 'bobos'—a term derived from 'bourgeois bohemians'—highlights a group that epitomizes this synthesis. He describes these individuals as having *"one foot in the bohemian world of creativity and another foot in the bourgeois realm of ambition and worldly success"* (Wang, 2008, p. 182). This duality reflects broader societal emulation, where global trends are localized not merely to enhance status but to redefine cultural identity in contemporary China.

Wang emphasizes the role of market segmentation and consumer emulation in shaping these identities. He asserts, *"The consumer identifies with a given sociocultural segment or 'tribe'"* (Wang, 2008, p. 181). He notes that luxury brands such as Louis Vuitton and Prada are not merely seen as status symbols but as integral components of a 'bobos' identity, which seeks to emulate higher social tiers while retaining distinct cultural characteristics (Wang, 2008, 180). This emulation is layered—it reflects not only economic capacity but also a strategic cultural positioning, showing how global consumerism is adapted within local cultural narratives.

Wang also emphasizes the role of advertising in shaping these new identities. He illustrates with the example of *"Advertising copy cashed in on bobo fever"* (Wang, 2008, p.

183), noting that media plays a crucial role in shaping these new identities, where advertisements promote not only products but also certain lifestyles and identities, blending commercial and cultural narratives. This interplay between global consumer culture and local identity construction underscores the complex dynamics at play as global and local influences converge to shape personal and collective identities in modern societies.

Cynthia Chan, Lianne Yu, and Christopher Ireland, in "Yi (Style): China's New Culture of Cool," delve into the role of fashion and consumer culture as instruments for young Chinese individuals to forge and navigate their social identities. They highlight how global fashion trends are not just adopted in China but are adapted to fit within the local cultural milieu, leading to a unique synthesis. They note, *"What's distinctive about style in China, however, is that it incorporates all of these looks and integrates them in a way that is quintessentially Chinese"* (Chan et al., 2006, p. 5). This integration process underscores a reinforcement of national identity through the lens of global consumer culture, rather than its erosion.

The authors argue that this blending of global styles with local nuances remains *"quintessentially Chinese,"* showcasing the youth's ability to reinterpret and personalize global influences within a distinctly Chinese aesthetic (Chan et al., 2006, p. 5). This phenomenon of cultural assimilation and adaptation is indicative of a strong element of cultural hybridity, where global influences are seamlessly combined with local traditions and values. This supports the thesis that global media flows have catalyzed new forms of cultural hybridity, effectively leveraging global consumer culture to enhance and celebrate authentic local cultural expressions.

### **Case Study: Squid Game**

"Squid Game" offers a powerful illustration of how global media flows catalyze the development of hybrid cultural identities, melding local traditions with global influences. As

a seminal example, it embodies the themes explored throughout our discussion on the impact of global media on cultural identity, making it an ideal case study. This analysis integrates theoretical insights from the literature on global media and identity, critically assessing how "Squid Game" exemplifies these concepts while highlighting the series' portrayal of global economic disparities and cultural tensions.

Hyejung Ju underscores the transformative role of platforms like Netflix in elevating local shows to global phenomena through transcultural broadcasting. She notes that "local shows metamorphose into global phenomena" (Ju, 2020, p. 171), a process vividly exemplified by "Squid Game." With its sharp focus on themes of socio-economic disparity and survival competition, the series taps into the global stage, presenting a story deeply rooted in Korean culture yet resonating on a global scale. This widespread accessibility enables viewers around the world to engage actively, not just as passive consumers but as interpreters and participants in its rich cultural narrative.

Similarly, Brian Larkin discusses the significant impact of media in shaping societal views under the pressures of globalization (Larkin, 2008, p. 170). "Squid Game" mirrors this concept, using its gripping narrative to reflect and critique the dynamics of global capitalism while addressing specific socio-economic issues within South Korea. This approach highlights the series' role as a critical tool for societal reflection and debate, illustrating the complex interactions between local cultural elements and global media influences. Through "Squid Game," we see how media not only entertains but also serves as a catalyst for critical thought and discussion regarding broader societal issues.

The narrative of "Squid Game," where characters are driven by desperate economic circumstances, powerfully mirrors global economic realities and critiques the structures that exacerbate such disparities. This alignment is highlighted by Chris Barker, who notes in

“Capitalism and ‘Global Television’” of how media globalization often reproduces economic inequalities while simultaneously offering a critique of these disparities. (Barker, 2019, p. 21-22). Thus, "Squid Game" emerges as a significant medium for global viewers to confront and engage in discussions about the harsh realities of economic disparity, reflecting the dual role of media as both a mirror and a critic of societal issues.

Building on Brian Larkin's observations, "Squid Game" incorporates themes that resonate deeply in both local and global contexts, similar to those found in Nigerian cinema where religious and secular narratives coexist. Larkin discusses the significant role of media in addressing themes of prosperity and moral conflict, influenced by religious movements and traditional beliefs (Larkin, 2008, p. 170). In "Squid Game," the intertwining of life-and-death stakes with personal moral dilemmas under economic duress reflects these themes, enhancing the series' universal appeal and relevance.

Netflix's role in distributing "Squid Game" globally has reshaped how cultural products are consumed, leveraging its algorithm to promote shows based on viewer preferences, thus broadening the reach of non-Western media and altering their global perception and reception (Ju, 2020, p. 172). This dynamic underscores the complex interactions of cultural exchange and consumer culture, challenging the traditional dominance of Western narratives and providing a platform for diverse global discussions on societal issues.

"Squid Game" powerfully supports the thesis that global media flows foster new forms of cultural hybridity that enrich local cultural expressions. Its success demonstrates how local narratives can become integral parts of the global dialogue without losing their cultural specificity. The series exemplifies how global media can enhance local identity through content that resonates on both local and global scales, contributing to a richer global cultural mosaic.



"Squid Game" is a prime example of how global media platforms like Netflix are instrumental in transforming local media productions into global cultural phenomena. The series not only highlights critical social issues pertinent to Korean society but also elevates these issues to a global stage, allowing for complex dialogue between diverse audiences. Through this case study, we observe the embodiment of the theoretical frameworks discussed, demonstrating the capacity of global media to enrich cultural identities through hybridity and transcultural engagements.

Drawing on Brian Larkin's perspective, media such as "Squid Game" reflect and actively engage with societal insecurities, shaping both national and global identities (Larkin, 2008, p. 170). The series dramatizes South Korea's competitive culture and economic disparities, themes with universal relevance that resonate globally, challenging the mere consumerist portrayal of cultures. This engagement provides a platform for deeper public discourse, influencing perceptions and potentially driving social change.

Paul Cooke's insights into East German nostalgia (Ostalgie) reveal how global media can commodify cultural histories, simplifying complex identities to appeal to consumer markets (Cooke, 2005, p. 134). Contrary to this trend, "Squid Game" uses its narrative to critique these capitalist dynamics, presenting a counter-narrative that preserves cultural specificity while engaging global audiences. This approach aligns with the continuous cultural interaction model proposed by Larkin, where media serves as a dynamic space for the intermingling of local and universal themes, fostering ongoing cultural adaptation and interaction (Larkin, 2008, p. 169).

Slavoj Žižek's critique of global media, particularly through the lens of his concept that *"The global capitalist system is approaching an apocalyptic zero-point"* (Žižek, 2014, p. 85). His analysis sharply encapsulates the dual role of global media under capitalist ideologies.

While global media propagate capitalist values, commodifying cultural identities and turning them into marketable products, they simultaneously provide a platform for subversion and critique. "Squid Game" serves as a poignant case study in this context. It not only operates within the capitalist framework but also mounts a scathing critique against it, exemplifying how media can both reflect and resist the commodification of human suffering and societal inequities. By dramatizing a brutal competition for survival under severe economic distress, "Squid Game" mirrors real-world socioeconomic issues, prompting viewers to reflect critically on global disparities. Thus, the series underscores the potential of global media to not merely reinforce existing power dynamics, but to challenge and potentially transform them, fostering a more equitable global cultural exchange.

### **Conclusion**

This essay has explored the transformative impact of global media flows on cultural identities, using "Squid Game" as a case study to illustrate how these flows encourage cultural hybridity, enriching rather than eroding local identities. The series not only mirrors societal insecurities but also prompts a global dialogue about economic disparity and social competition, showing the power of local narratives to influence global media landscapes.

The implications of these findings are significant for the future of global media and cultural identity construction. They highlight the potential of global platforms like Netflix to facilitate meaningful cultural exchange while also underscoring the need for media producers to balance economic interests with ethical considerations of cultural representation.

In sum, as global media continues to evolve, it presents opportunities to foster enriched and nuanced cultural identities, promoting a deeper understanding and appreciation of cultural diversity across the globe. This dynamic landscape offers vast potential for further research into the interplay between media and cultural identity in our increasingly interconnected world.

## **Works Cited**

Barker, Chris. *Global Television*, London: Blackwell 1997, p. 3-26

Chan, Cynthia, et al. *Yi (Style): China's New Culture of Cool: Understanding the World's Fastest-Growing Market*. Berkeley, California, 2007..

Cooke, Paul. *Ostalgie's Not What It Used to Be, German Studies: University of Leeds*, 2003.

Ju, Hyejung. "K-Dramas Meet Netflix: New models of collaboration with the digital West." 2020, p. 171-183.

Larkin, Brian. *"Signal and Noise: Media, Infrastructure, and Urban Culture in Nigeria."*, Durham: Duke University Press, 2008.

Wang, Jing. *"Brand New China: Advertising, Media, and Commercial Culture"*. Cambridge: Havard University Press. 2008

Zizek, Slavoj. *Trouble in Paradise: From the End of History to the End of Capitalism*. Melville House, 2014.